

Chosen as Jyoti Basu's successor due to his ability to balance the hardliners and the liberals in the CPI(M), Buddhadeb is in danger of losing the backing of both his party and the people

■ By Satarupa Bhattacharya and Swagata Sen

At least two afternoons every week, West Bengal's cultural affairs minister pays a visit to Nandan, the state's hub for everything connected to the arts. That is, the afternoons when he can extricate himself from more pressing matters. Matters that deal with blood, gore, landwars, police inefficiency, and murders most foul. For Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, also chief minister, it is definitely not a time to be savouring Rabindra Sangeet.

The West Bengal chief minister is an increasingly troubled man these days and it is beginning to show. Last week, when he announced that he had sent a letter to Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil seeking the CRPF's intervention in Nandigram, saying, "This cannot go on", there was a resigned acceptance that things had, after all, not gone according to plan. The project closest to his heart, the SEZ of the Salim Group of Indonesia that was to be carved out of battle-torn Nandigram, is still looking for an alternative location. Nayachar, an island off the Haldia coast, for which grand plans of a connecting bridge had even been declared, has been rendered useless due to ecological concerns expressed by the Geological Survey of India. The case of Rizwanur Rahman's mysterious death—which resulted in the removal of ex-police commissioner Prasun Mukherjee from his post and which continues to provide new leads almost every day—has left the state administration with egg on its face and CBI at its heels. And bete noire Mamata Banerjee, who still resents the fact that the Tatas' car factory is actually being built on state land in Singur, has decided to protest every one of his moves, especially in Nandigram, where she claims she was shot at last week while she was touring the area. Fearing

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for their lives, scores of CPI(M) supporters have sought refuge in nearby Khejuri, and their constant attempts to recapture their villages sparked off violence even last week.

In 2000, Bhattacharya was chosen as the then chief minister Jyoti Basu's successor not just because he could balance both the hardliners and the liberals in the party, but also because—with a clean, efficient image of a well-read and soft-spoken man—he was deemed capable of taking West Bengal into the new century through pragmatic Communism. Carrying the image of the modern Communist forward, he would give out choice quotes. He once famously answered a reporter's question about Singur at the Writer's Building with one from Shakespeare,

trailing off, "There are many things on Heaven and Earth, Horatio...." The same Bhattacharya chooses to stay silent to pointed questions from the media most of the time these days. Last week, when asked what he thought of the success of a Trinamool-declared bandh in Kolkata, he replied with a curt, "What do I know?"

Worse, he receives flak from his own party members. Basu has been vocal against his handling of the Rahman case, as well as Nandigram. Basu is, in fact, altogether not in favour of the Salim SEZ. After Nandigram, for the first time, CPI(M)'s Front allies BSP, CPI and Forward Bloc threatened to walk out of the government. Almost all leaders of these parties have just one complaint today—Bhattacharya has